



FROM ZERO TO PRO - MODULE 10

Global Cuisines: French, Italian, Asian & Latin

Apply your fundamentals across four major traditions and learn the pantry and techniques of each.

Weeks 17-19 - watch, study, cook, reflect

By the end of this module

1 Cook a fresh pasta and an emulsified pasta sauce (Italian).

2 Build a stir-fry with wok hei principles (Asian).

3 Make a salsa, a braise, and handle masa basics (Latin).

4 Execute a classic French bistro plate end to end.

LESSON 10.1

Italian: Pasta and Sauce

Objective: Make fresh pasta and emulsify a pasta sauce properly.

Key points

- Cook pasta in well-salted water to al dente - it finishes in the sauce.
- Save starchy pasta water; it is the key to emulsified sauce.
- Toss pasta and sauce hard in the pan to bind fat and water.
- Sauce should coat the pasta, not pool around it.

Technique

- 1 Boil**
Cook pasta in salted water until just shy of al dente.
- 2 Combine**
Move pasta into the pan with the sauce and some pasta water.
- 3 Emulsify**
Toss vigorously over heat until glossy and clinging.
- 4 Finish**
Adjust with more water, cheese, or fat to a silky coat.

LESSON 10.2

Asian: The Stir-Fry

Objective: Cook a fast, high-heat stir-fry with proper prep.

Key points

- Prep everything first - stir-frying is too fast to chop mid-cook.
- Use very high heat and cook in stages to avoid steaming.
- Balance salty, sweet, sour, and umami in the sauce.
- Aromatics (garlic, ginger, chili) go in fast and must not burn.

Technique

- 1 Prep**
Cut everything to even sizes; line up in cooking order.
- 2 Heat**
Get the wok or pan very hot before adding oil.
- 3 Cook in stages**
Sear proteins, then vegetables, keeping things moving.
- 4 Sauce**
Add the balanced sauce at the end and toss to coat.

LESSON 10.3

Latin: Salsas and Braises

Objective: Build fresh salsas and a flavorful braise.

Key points

- Salsas layer chiles, acid, alliums, and herbs for brightness.
- Toasting or charring components deepens salsa and braise flavor.
- Latin braises build from toasted chiles and spices, cooked low and slow.
- Beans, rice, and masa complete the plate.

Watch out for

- Skipping the toast/char step, leaving flavors flat.
- Under-acidifying a salsa, so it tastes dull.
- Rushing a braise before the meat is shreddable.

LESSON 10.4

French Bistro Classics

Objective: Execute a classic French plate that ties earlier modules together.

Key points

- Bistro plates combine a seared protein, a pan sauce, a vegetable, and a starch.
- It is fundamentals done precisely, not exotic technique.
- Season, rest, and sauce with care; keep vegetables vivid.
- A few mastered bistro dishes form a lifelong repertoire.

Watch out for

- Treating 'simple' as 'careless' - bistro food exposes sloppy technique.
- A pan sauce that is unbalanced or greasy.
- Overcooked, dull vegetables next to a good protein.

Practice & homework

1

Make fresh pasta by hand and sauce it with an emulsified butter or tomato sauce.

2

Cook a high-heat stir-fry with properly prepped mise en place.

3

Prepare one Latin braise plus a fresh salsa to accompany it.

Watch & learn (free)



J. Kenji Lopez-Alt (food science & technique)

<https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt>



Ethan Chlebowski (the 'why' behind cooking)

<https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski>



Pro Home Cooks (skill-building series)

<https://www.youtube.com/@ProHomeCooks>



Brian Lagerstrom (ex-restaurant pro, approachable)

<https://www.youtube.com/@BrianLagerstrom>



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Next up - Module 11: Flavor, Seasoning & Menu Development

FROM ZERO TO PRO - THE SELF-TAUGHT CHEF PROGRAM